

E-mergency of Memory

Archiving Grief in the Age of Platform Precarity

A Mixed-Methods Study of Memorialized Social Media Accounts as Emergent Sites of Collective Grief and Digital Heritage

Simanta Nandi — Digital Humanities and Social Sciences, IIT (ISM) Dhanbad — 25ma0013@iitism.ac.in — +91 76020 42535

ABSTRACT

Abstract

This paper examines the emergent phenomenon of digital mourning, exploring how contemporary English-language social media profiles (2020–2024) transform into fragile ‘digital shrines.’ Responding to the conference theme of Emergence/ia, the study posits that digital remnants act as emergent sites for collective grief while exposing the precarious durability of platform-governed memorials. Grounded in critical platform studies and thanatosociology — drawing on Patrick Stokes (2021) and José van Dijk (2013, 2021) — this research investigates the tension between the human desire for permanent memory and the ephemeral reality of corporate social media ecosystems. A mixed-methods approach analysed fifty memorialized Facebook and Instagram accounts: computational sentiment analysis and structural topic modelling (LDA) were paired with qualitative close reading to assess affordances, constraints, and algorithmic governance. Results reveal five dominant grief-discourse topics, a measurable negative-to-positive sentiment arc over 24 months, and clear evidence of emergent ‘digital solidarity’ archiving practices. We propose a four-layer ‘Critical Care’ model for institutionalizing digital mourning as cultural heritage.

Keywords: digital mourning · platform precarity · online memorialization · thanatosociology · sentiment analysis · topic modelling · digital solidarity · cultural heritage

1 · INTRODUCTION

The Emergency of Memory

When a person dies in the twenty-first century, their social media profiles rarely disappear with them. By mid-2024, Facebook alone was projected to host hundreds of millions of deceased-user profiles, with some researchers estimating dead accounts will outnumber living ones before the century’s end (Öhman & Watson, 2019; ExpressVPN, 2024). Facebook has quietly become the world’s largest cemetery — governed not by ecclesiastical law or civic ordinance, but by a constantly-revised Terms of Service and an opaque recommendation algorithm.

As platforms exercise sovereign power over billions of memorial accounts, ordinary people perform ‘**curatorial labour**’: screenshotting posts, building shared drives, establishing memory groups, and deploying extraction tools to rescue digital remains from algorithmic flux. These grassroots responses constitute ‘**digital solidarity**,’ an emergent, decentralized form of collective archiving that this paper is among the first to name and systematically study.

2 · LITERATURE

Theoretical Frameworks

2.1 Thanatosociology & the ‘Second Death’

Patrick Stokes’s Digital Souls (2021) argues social network profiles offer a materially distinct instantiation of personhood, capable of surviving biological death as an ‘ethical patient.’ His earlier framing of deletion as ‘second death’ (Stokes, 2015) is foundational to understanding platform precarity. Davide Sisto’s Online Afterlives (2020) examines new immortality desires — from static memorial pages to AI chatbots simulating the deceased.

2.2 Platform Studies & Algorithmic Governance

José van Dijk’s The Culture of Connectivity (2013) shows platforms are not neutral conduits but active mediators that embed commercial values — popularity, ranking, traffic — into the architecture of sociality. Her subsequent work on platformization and deplatformization (2021, 2022) maps the volatile, uncurated nature of ecosystems that can be restructured, sold, or shut down at any moment.

2.3 Continuing Bonds & Digital Mourning

Klass, Silverman & Nickman’s continuing bonds theory (1996) holds that healthy grief involves sustaining — not severing — a connection with the deceased. Rossetto et al. (2015) and Church (2013) document Facebook profiles as instruments of release, representation, and ongoing mourning. The COVID-19 pandemic radically accelerated digital mourning as physical funerals were banned worldwide.

2.4 The Gap This Study Addresses

Existing scholarship documents that digital remains are valued — but not how communities act to preserve them against corporate threat. ‘Curatorial labour,’ adapted here from digital humanities, describes the often-invisible preservation work surviving communities perform without institutional support — the ground floor of our proposed Critical Care model.

3 · METHODOLOGY

Corpus & Mixed-Methods Design

Our corpus comprised 50 publicly accessible memorialized accounts (27 Facebook, 23 Instagram), collected January 2020 – December 2024 via purposive sampling and snowball referral. Inclusion required formal memorialization status, English-language content, 12+ months of post-mortem activity, and 30+ visible posts. Ethical review followed AoIR (2020) guidelines; accounts were anonymised with alphanumeric codes (FB-01–27, IG-01–23).



Sentiment analysis used a two-stage pipeline: VADER (lexicon-based) generated compound scores, followed by a fine-tuned RoBERTa transformer to capture grief-specific emotional registers (Cohen’s κ = 0.74 inter-method agreement). Structural Topic Modelling applied Latent Dirichlet Allocation (Gensim) with coherence-optimised $k = 5$ ($C_v = 0.58$). Computational findings were triangulated through qualitative close reading of 180 purposively selected posts using constructivist grounded theory (Charmaz, 2014), yielding three categories: sacralization practices, platform-anxiety discourse, and digital solidarity actions.

4.1 · RESULTS

The Emotional Arc of Digital Grief

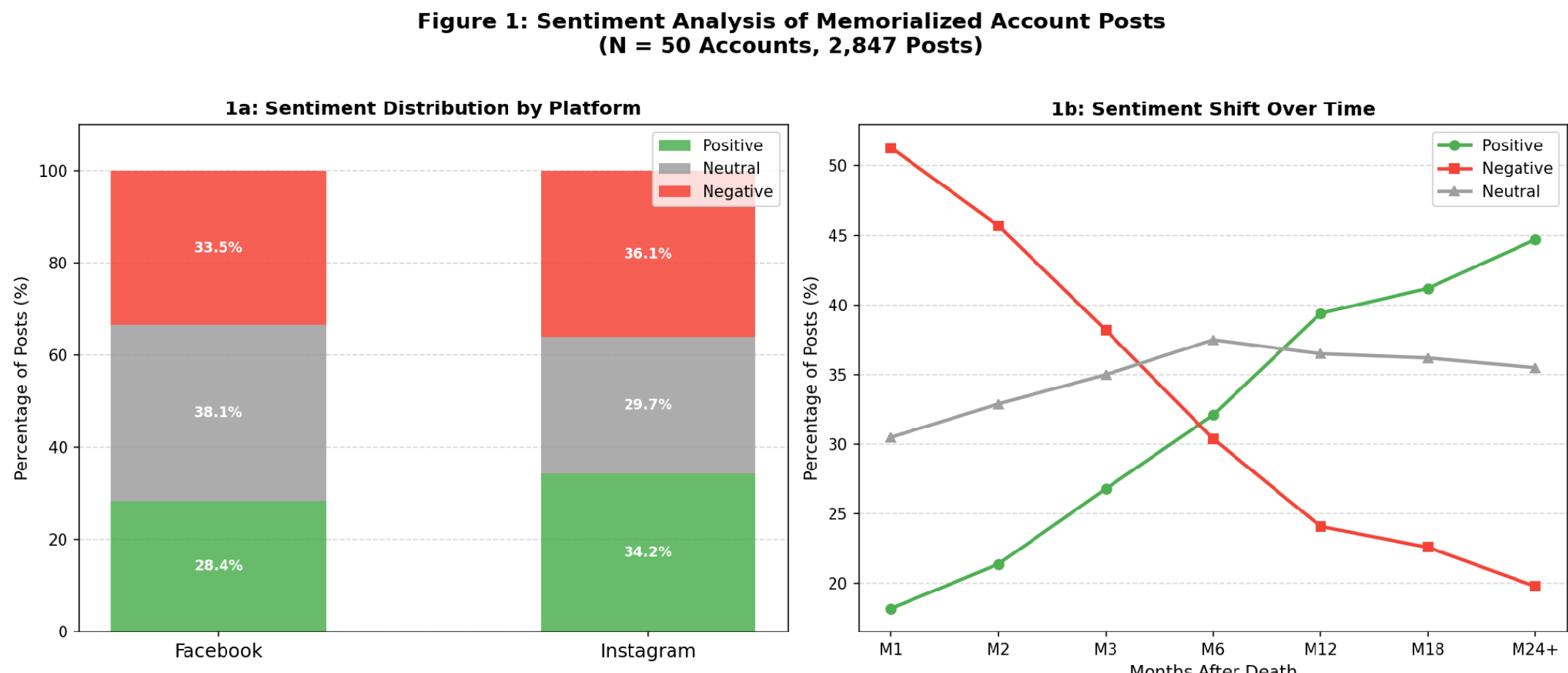


Figure 1. Sentiment distribution by platform and 24-month sentiment arc. Source: authors’ computational analysis of 2,847 posts.

33.5% (FB) / 36.1% (IG) of posts registered negative sentiment, versus 28.4% / 34.2% positive. A temporal analysis reveals a consistent arc: an acute negative peak in Month 1 (51.3%) declines to a residual 19.8% by Month 24, while positive sentiment rises from 18.2% to 44.7% — mirroring Stroebe & Schut’s (1999) oscillation model of grief, digitally elongated by persistent profile access. A RoBERTa sub-analysis identified ‘platform-anxiety discourse’ in 11.4% of Instagram accounts — a previously unnamed state we term ‘memorial precarity anxiety.’

4.2 · RESULTS

Five Themes of Digital Grief Discourse

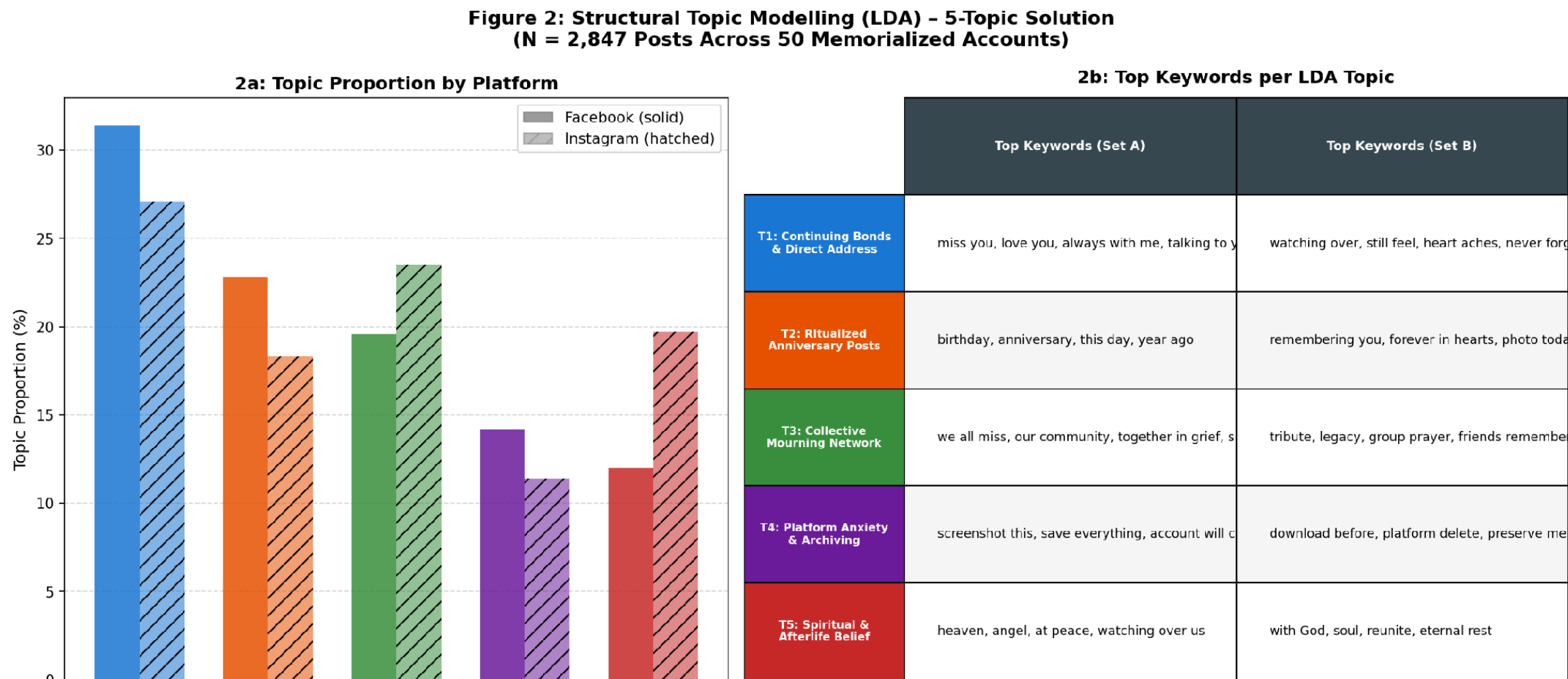


Figure 2. LDA topic-modelling results ($k = 5$). Source: authors’ analysis using Gensim (Python).

- Continuing Bonds & Direct Address — 31.4% / 27.1% (dominant topic)
- Ritualized Anniversary Posting — 22.8% / 18.3%
- Collective Mourning & Solidarity — 19.6% / 23.5% (stronger on IG)
- Platform Anxiety & Archiving — 14.2% / 11.4% (curatorial labour evidence)
- Spiritual & Afterlife Belief — 12.0% / 19.7% (stronger on IG)

4.3–4.4 · RESULTS

Platform Precarity & Community Archiving

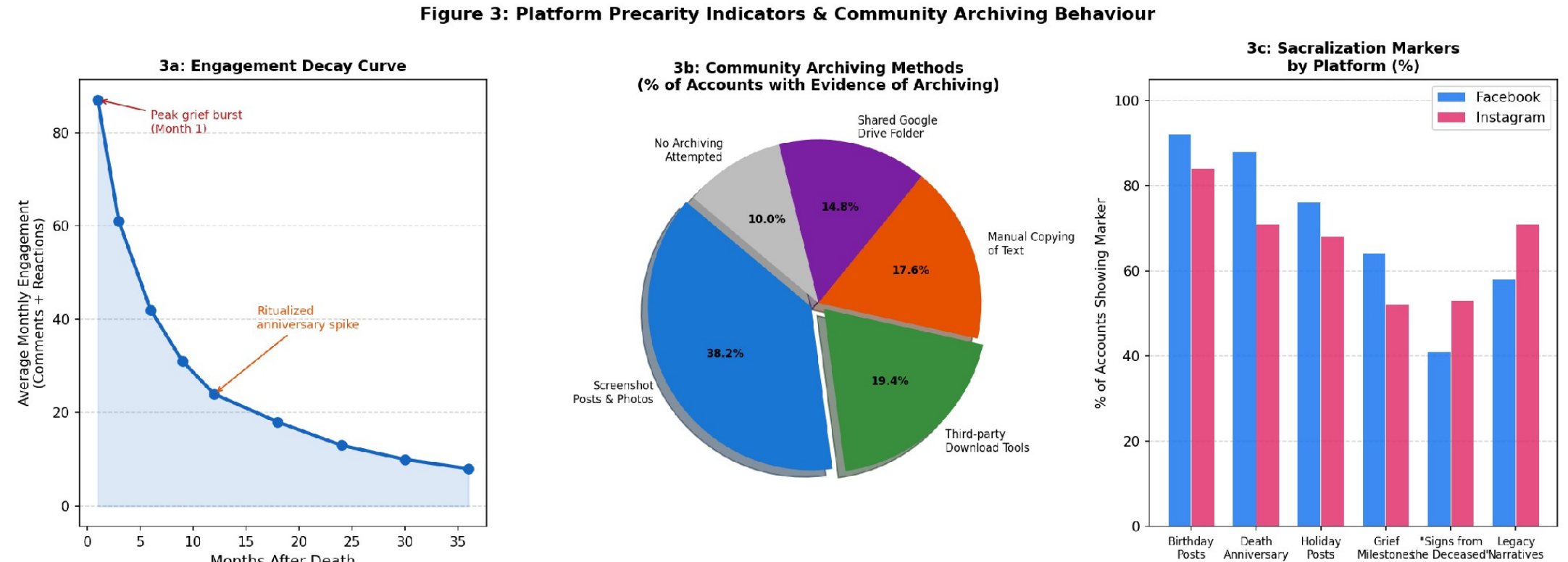


Figure 3. Engagement decay, archiving methods, and sacralization markers. Source: authors’ analysis.

Close reading of 180 posts identified systematic sacralization: 92% / 84% (FB/IG) of accounts show birthday ritual posting, 88% / 71% show death-anniversary posting. Community archiving was extensive — 38.2% of accounts show screenshot campaigns, 19.4% reference third-party download tools, 17.6% manual text-copying, and 14.8% shared cloud folders; only 10% show no archiving activity. Engagement decays from 87 to 8 interactions/month over 36 months, punctuated by a recurring ‘anniversary spike’ at Month 12 (24 vs. a predicted 15) — evidence that digital grief is rhythmically structured, not simply diminishing.

KEY FINDING — ‘MEMORIAL PRECARIETY ANXIETY’

“Please — before this page disappears — save every photo, every comment, every video. This is all we have left of him. Facebook doesn’t care about grief. Archive everything. Share this so people know.”

— Post on account FB-14, 18 months post-death · 11.4% of Instagram accounts showed comparable platform-anxiety discourse.

5 · DISCUSSION

Toward a Critical Care Model

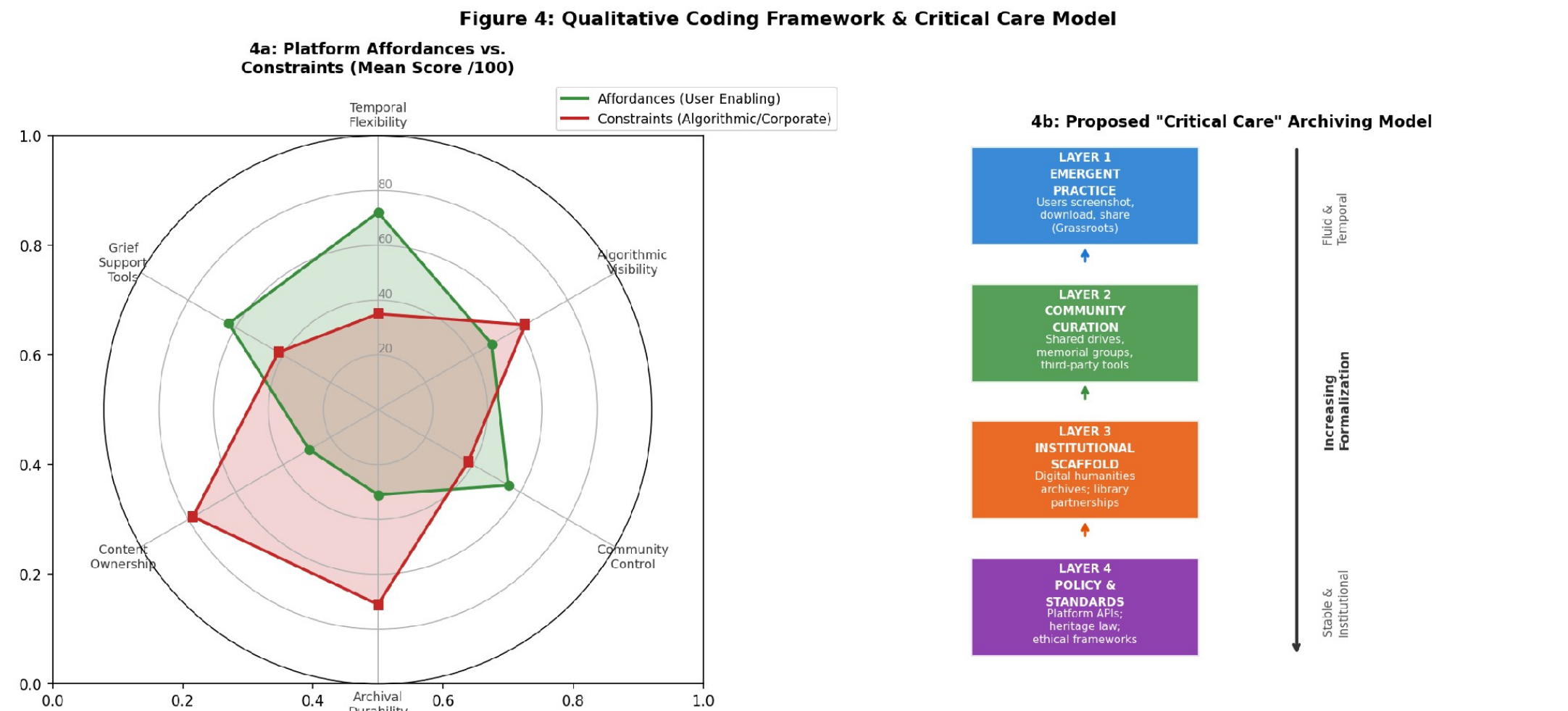


Figure 4. Affordances vs. constraints, and the four-layer Critical Care model. Source: authors.

Platform governance constitutes an ‘emergency of memory’: communities invest profound significance in digital objects materially controlled by commercial entities with no fiduciary duty to preserve them. Our coded radar analysis shows platforms score lowest on archival durability (mean 31/100) and highest on algorithmic/corporate constraints around content ownership. Digital solidarity is both hopeful and precarious — third-party tools risk lockout, screenshots lose metadata, shared drives carry their own commercial precarity — replicating, at community level, the very precarity it seeks to escape. We propose four layers: (1) Emergent Practice, (2) Community Curation, (3) Institutional Scaffold, and (4) Policy & Standards — moving from grassroots response to systemic reform.

6 · CONCLUSION

The Emergency Is Already Here

This mixed-methods analysis of 50 memorialized accounts shows digital mourning to be richer and more precarious than existing scholarship acknowledges. For digital humanists, memorialized accounts are legitimate cultural-heritage objects; for platform designers, current affordances are structurally inadequate to memorial needs; for policy makers, digital remains require urgent regulatory attention.

“The emergency of memory is already here. The response must be equally emergent.”

SELECTED REFERENCES

Klass, D., Silverman, P. R., & Nickman, S. L. (Eds.). (1996). Continuing bonds: New understandings of grief. Taylor & Francis.

Stokes, P. (2015). Deletion as second death: The moral status of digital remains. Ethics and Information Technology, 17(4), 237–248.

Stokes, P. (2021). Digital souls: A philosophy of online death. Bloomsbury Academic.

Sisto, D. (2020). Online afterlives: Immortality, memory, and grief in digital culture. MIT Press.

Van Dijk, J. (2013). The culture of connectivity: A critical history of social media. Oxford University Press.

Van Dijk, J., de Winkel, T., & Schäfer, M. T. (2021). Seeing the forest for the trees. New Media & Society, 24(2), 277–294.

Full 30-source reference list available in the accompanying paper.

Öhman, C., & Watson, D. (2019). Are the dead taking over Facebook? Big Data & Society, 6(1).

Hutto, C. J., & Gilbert, E. (2014). VADER: A parsimonious rule-based model for sentiment analysis of social media text. Proceedings of ICWSM.

Stroebe, M., & Schut, H. (1999). The dual process model of coping with bereavement. Death Studies, 23(3), 197–224.

Charmaz, K. (2014). Constructing grounded theory (2nd ed.). SAGE Publications.

Rossetto, K. R., Lannutti, P. J., & Strauman, E. C. (2015). Death on Facebook. Journal of Social and Personal Relationships, 32(7), 974–994.

Association of Internet Researchers (AoIR). (2020). Internet research: Ethical guidelines 3.0.

CONNECT WITH THE AUTHOR



Scan to email the author

Simanta Nandi

Digital Humanities and Social Sciences
IIT (ISM) Dhanbad

25ma0013@iitism.ac.in

Thank you for reading — questions and collaboration welcome.